



RADICAL

BE A KICK-ASS BOSS WITHOUT
LOSING YOUR HUMANITY



CANDOR

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LOSING YOUR HUMANITY

A Field Guide based on the philosophy of Kim Scott

THE DIAGNOSIS: RUINOUS EMPATHY

THE BOB PARADOX

WORD SALAD



WORD SALAD

Bob produces terrible work.

FALSE PRAISE



FALSE PRAISE

You say "Good start!" to spare feelings.

TEAM FAILURE



TEAM FAILURE

Peers clean up the mess; morale drops.

THE FIRING

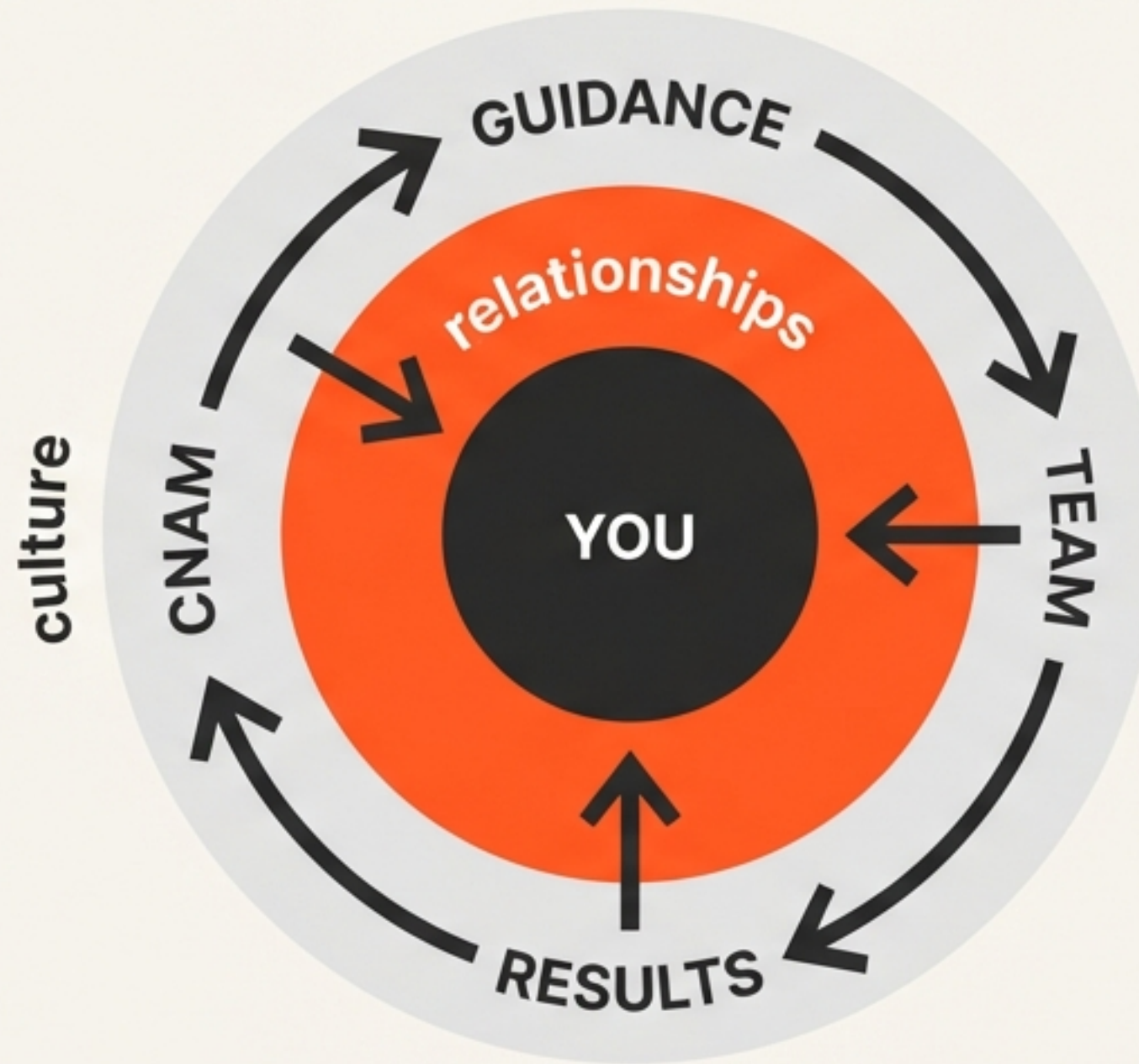


THE FIRING

Bob is fired. He asks: "Why didn't you tell me?"

“Being ‘nice’ is often the most unkind thing you can do.”

THE MANAGER'S ECOSYSTEM



Relationships, not power, drive you forward.

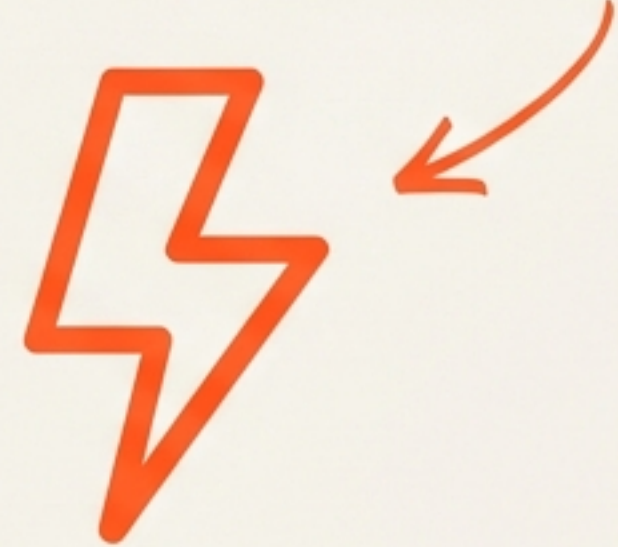
THE TWO DIMENSIONS OF TRUST

CARE PERSONALLY



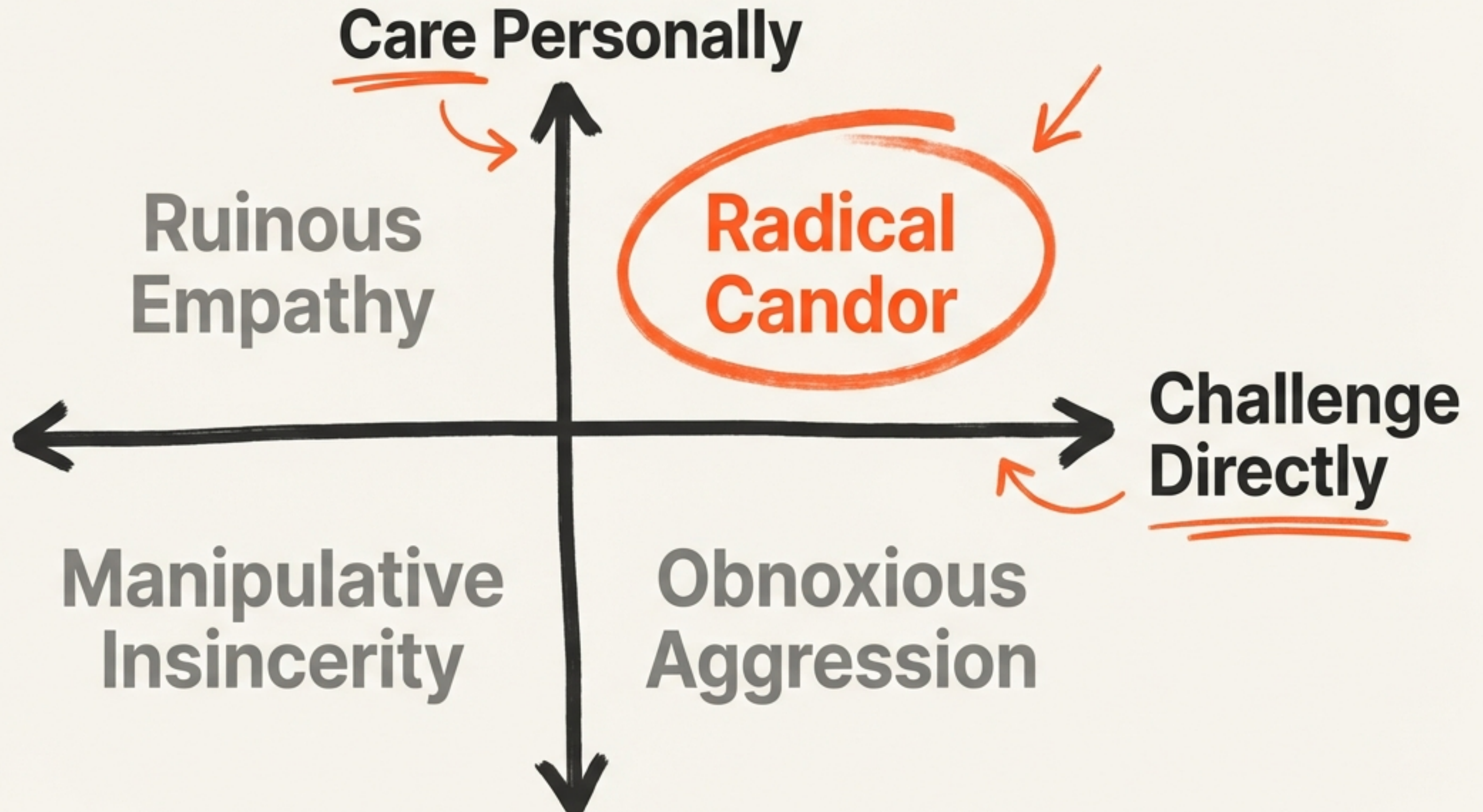
Bring your whole self to work. It is not just business; it is deeply personal. Acknowledging that we are all people with lives and aspirations.

CHALLENGE DIRECTLY



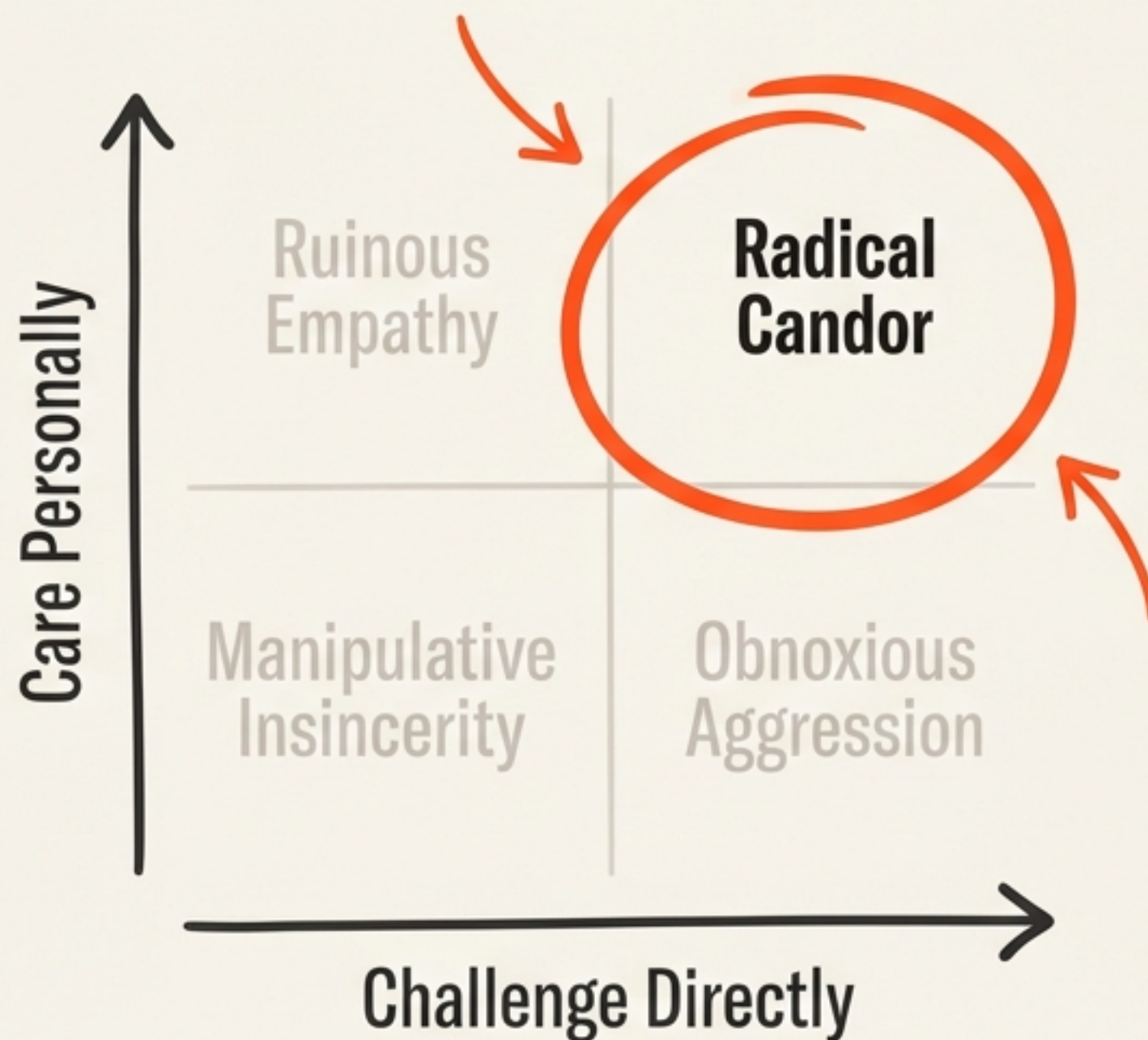
Telling people when their work isn't good enough—and when it is. Willingness to piss people off to help them improve.

THE FEEDBACK QUADRANT



RADICAL CANDOR

It's not mean, it's clear.



High Care + High Challenge = Trust.

The stranger didn't judge the owner. He cared about the dog's life and challenged the behavior directly.

OBNOXIOUS AGGRESSION

The Front-Stabber



 High Challenge, Low Care.

 Criticizing to humiliate rather than help.

 Belittling compliments.

 Gets short-term results, but leaves a trail of dead bodies.

"I refuse to work with people who can't be bothered to show basic human decency." 

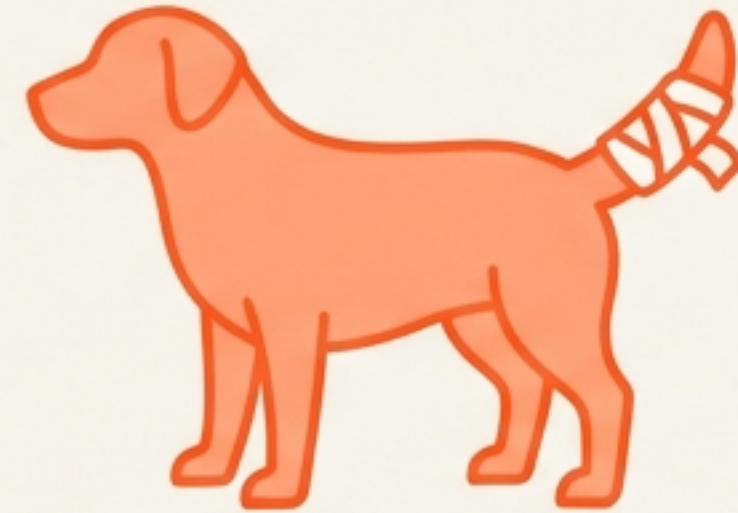
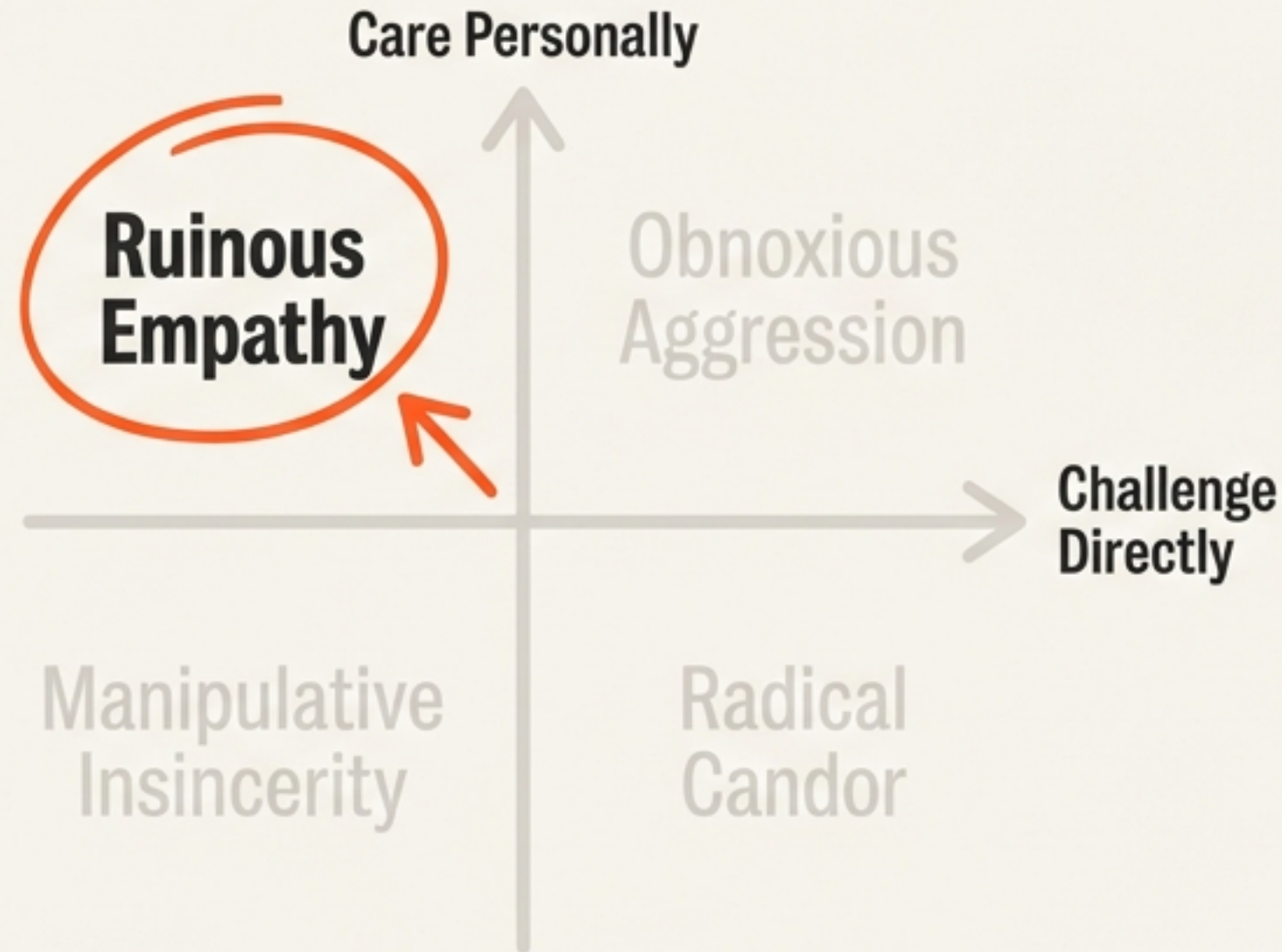
MANIPULATIVE INSINCERITY

The False Apology.



RUINOUS EMPATHY

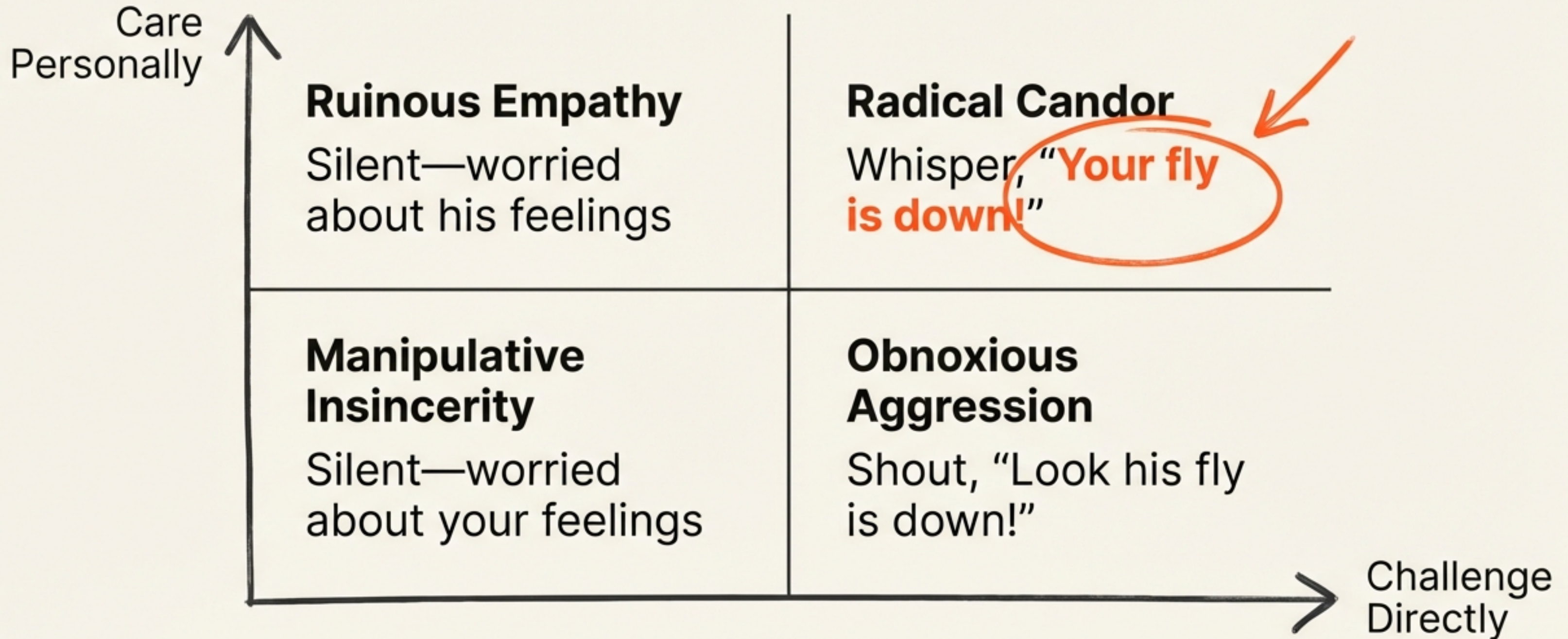
The Silent Killer.



- ✓ **Motivation:** "I don't want to hurt their feelings."
- ✓ **Outcome:** You spare them a moment of pain but cause a career of failure.
- ✓ **The Russian Anecdote:** Cutting the dog's tail off one inch at a time to "save it pain".

"If you don't have anything nice to say, it is your job to say it."

THE 'FLY DOWN' TEST

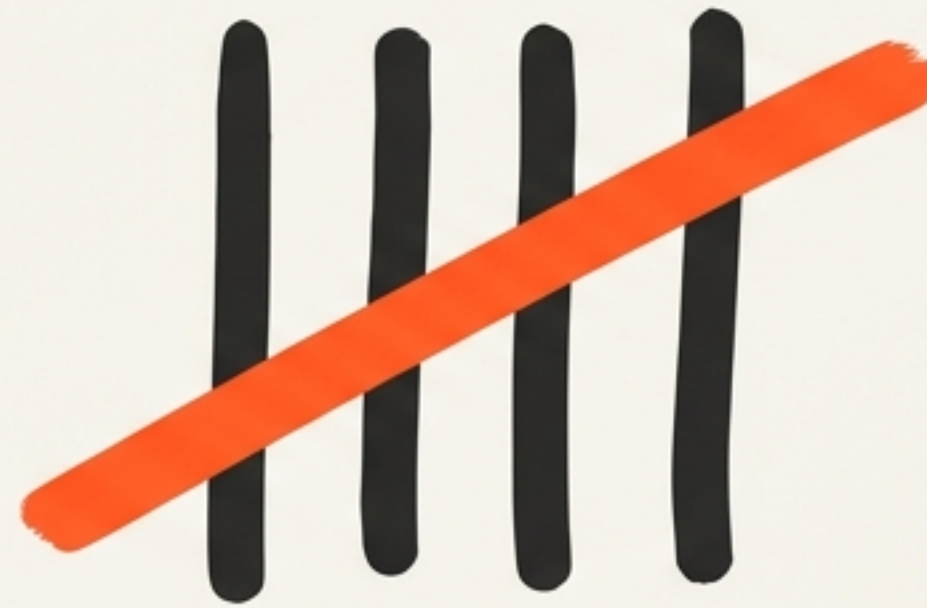


OPERATIONALIZING GUIDANCE

Case Study: The “Um” Story

Sincere Praise

You're going to have an amazing career... you handled those questions well.



The Result

Immediate, specific help (speech coach), not personalized judgment.

The Pivot

You said “um” a lot.

It makes you sound stupid.

Immediate. Specific. Helpful. Not Personalized.

THE ORDER OF OPERATIONS



Don't dish it out before you show you can take it.

WHAT RADICAL CANDOR IS NOT



NOT a license to be a jerk.

It's not Obnoxious Aggression.



NOT schmoozing.

It isn't about team dinners or laser tag. It is about truth.



NOT nitpicking.

Only challenge things that really matter.



NOT a hierarchy.

You must practice it up, down, and sideways.

CONTEXT MATTERS

Measured at the listener's ear.

ISRAEL



The Shout.

High-conflict culture accepted direct challenge as a sign of respect.

JAPAN



Polite Persistence.

Quietly but relentlessly presenting the data until heard.

Adjust your delivery, but never lose the candor.

RETHINK AMBITION

ROCK STAR



Solid as a rock. Steeped in stability.
Excellent performance, Gradual Growth.

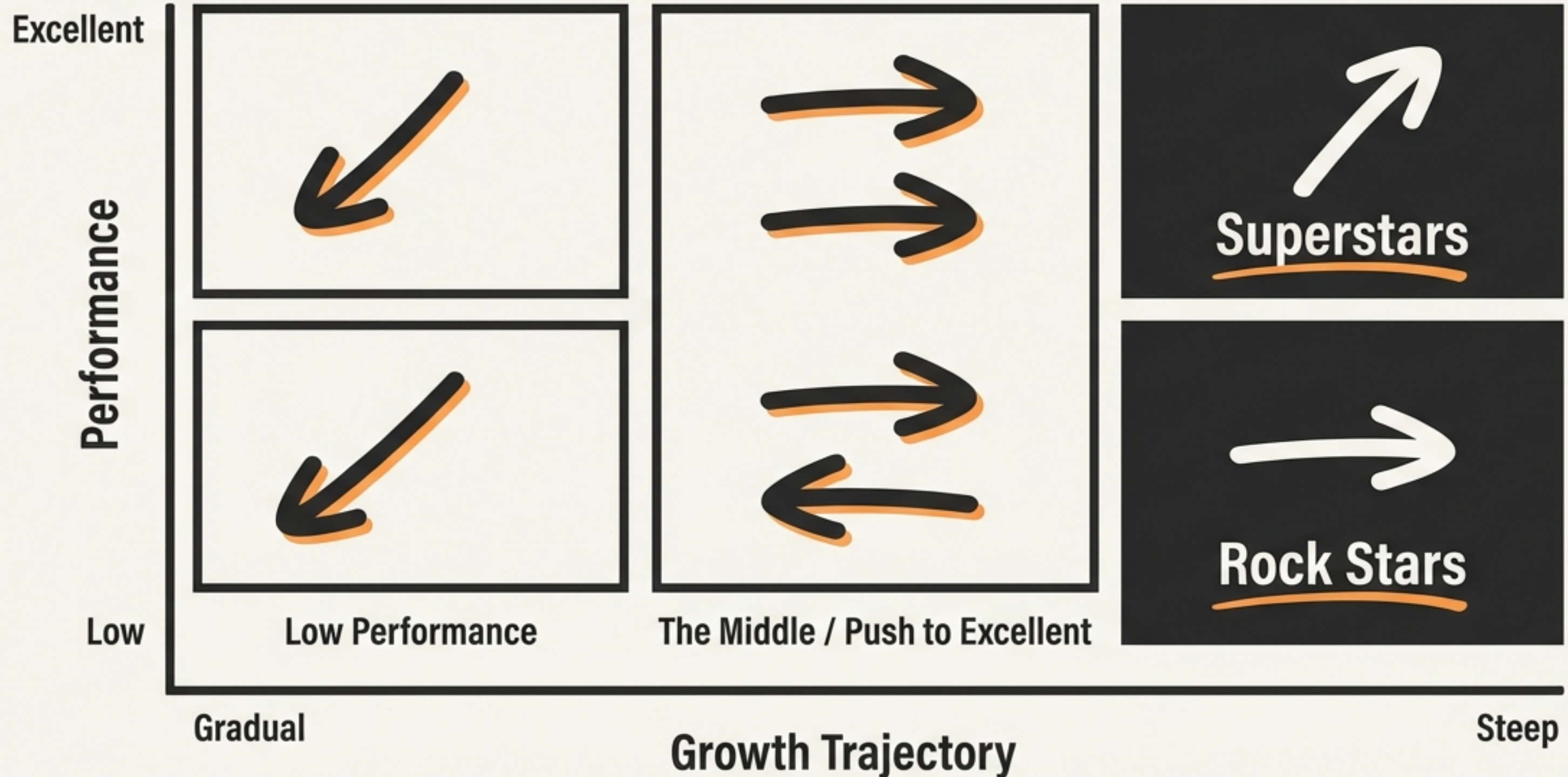
SUPERSTAR



Blazing fast. Steeped in change.
Excellent performance, Steep Growth.

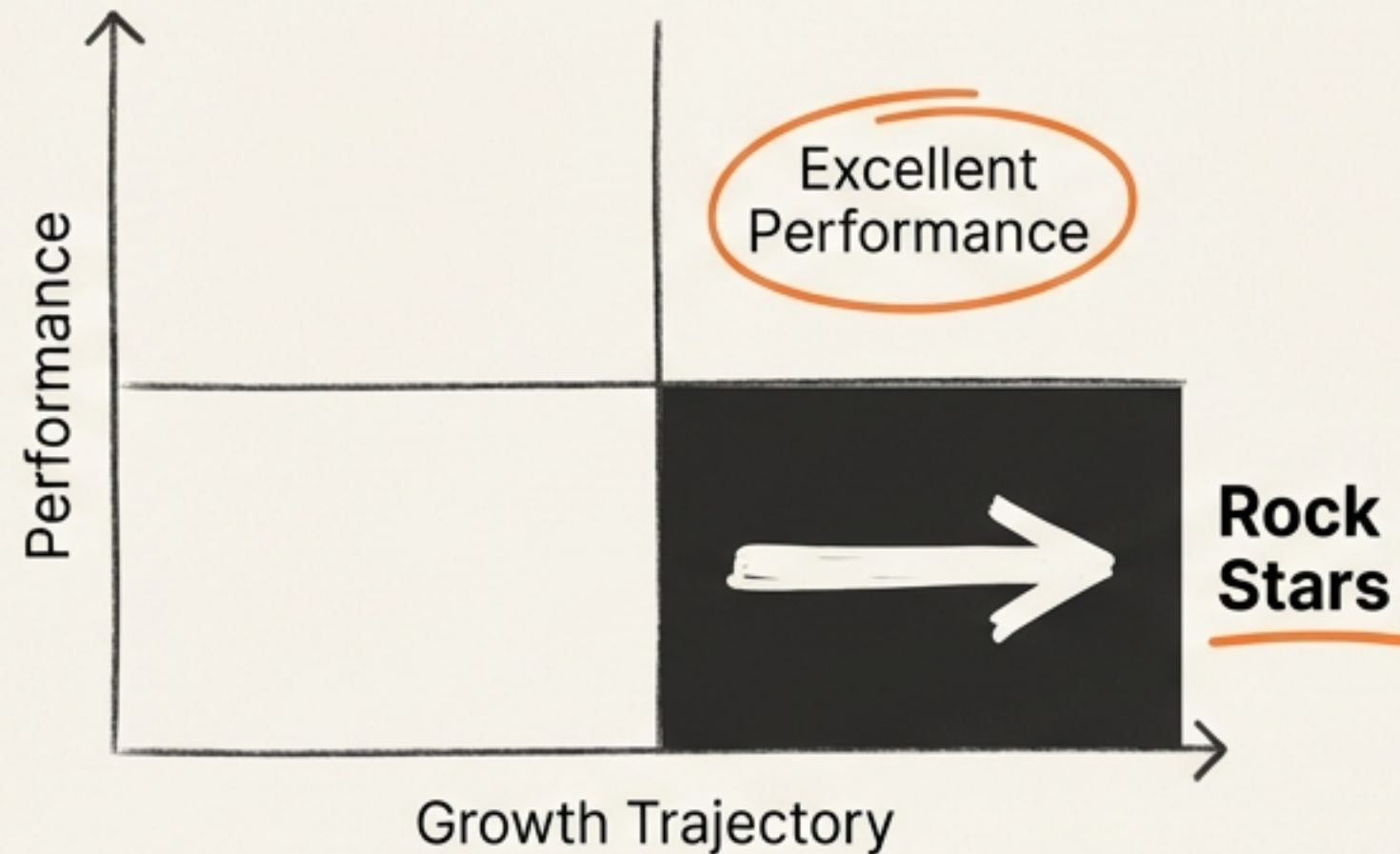
If everyone is a superstar, you have no stability.
If everyone is a rock star, you have no growth.

THE GROWTH MANAGEMENT MATRIX



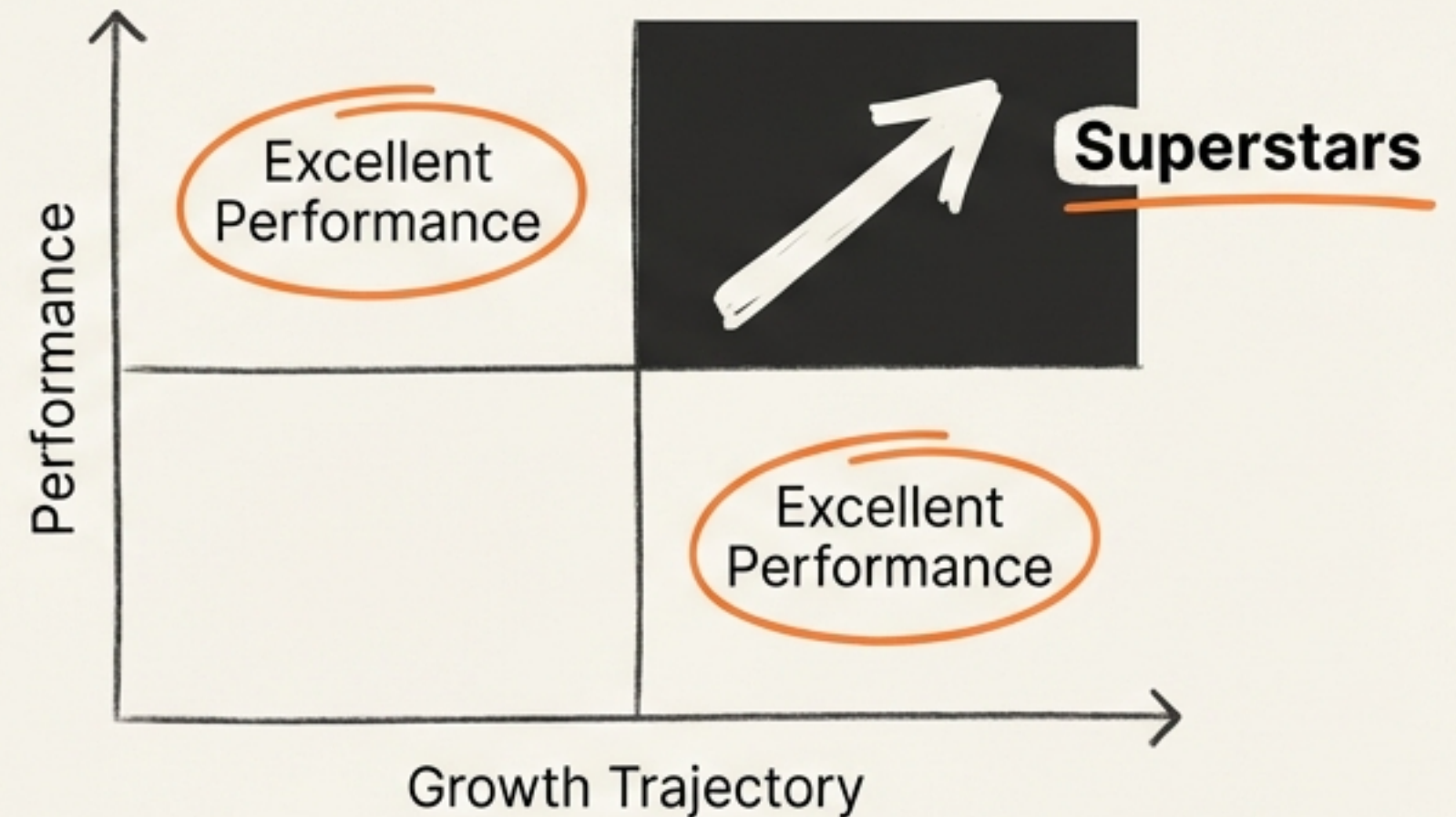
MANAGING EXCELLENCE

ROCK STARS (Gradual Growth)



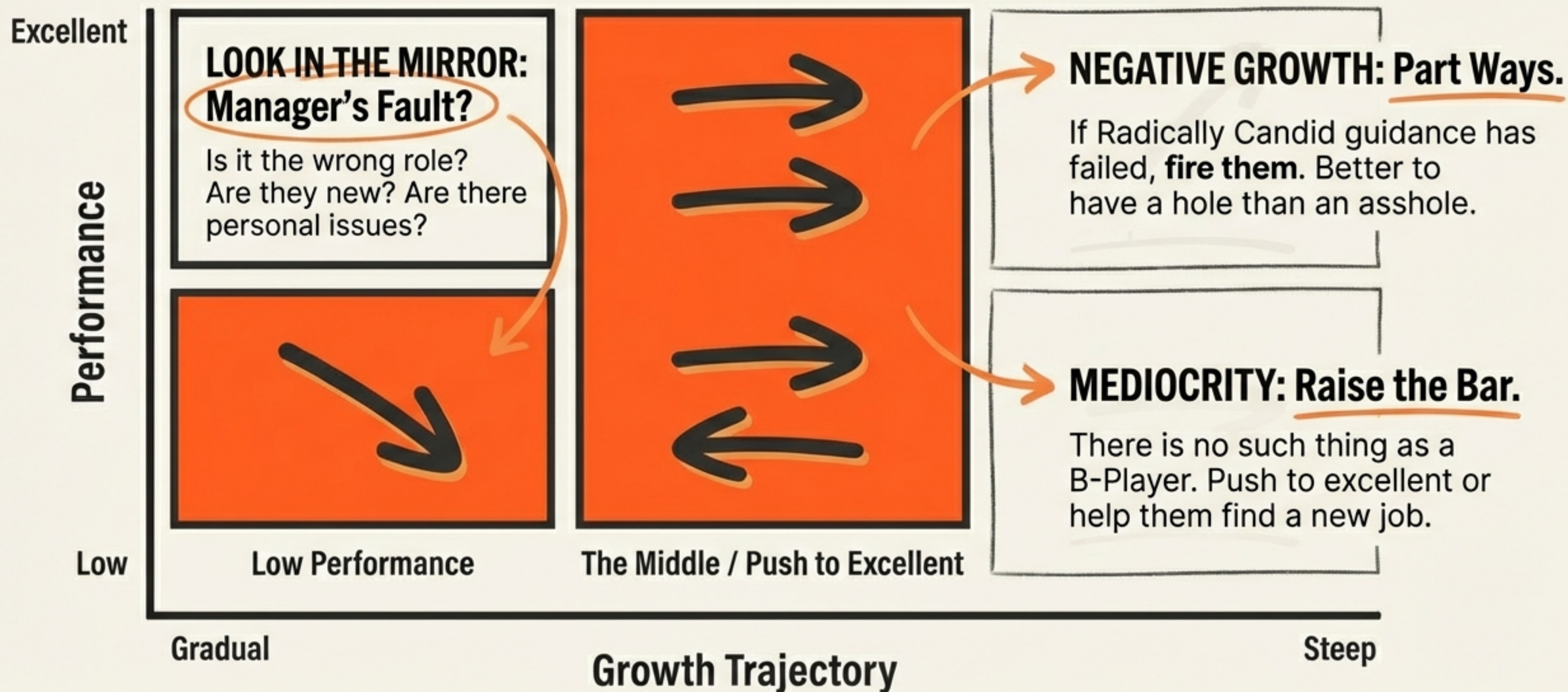
- **DO:** Honor tenure, give guru status, fair compensation.
- **DON'T:** Force promotions or treat them as "capped out".

SUPERSTARS (Steep Growth)



- **DO:** Give new challenges, find mentors, plan for their replacement.
- **DON'T:** Squash them or block transfers.

WHEN IT'S NOT WORKING



TELLING PEOPLE WHAT TO DO DOESN'T WORK



The Google Paradox:
The Google Paradox: Autocratic decision-making creates chaos, not order.

Collaborative debate > Command and control.

THE ART OF COLLABORATION



“I don’t mind being wrong. And I’ll admit that I’m wrong a lot... What matters to me is that we do the right thing.” — Steve Jobs



LISTEN

(Seek to understand)



DEBATE

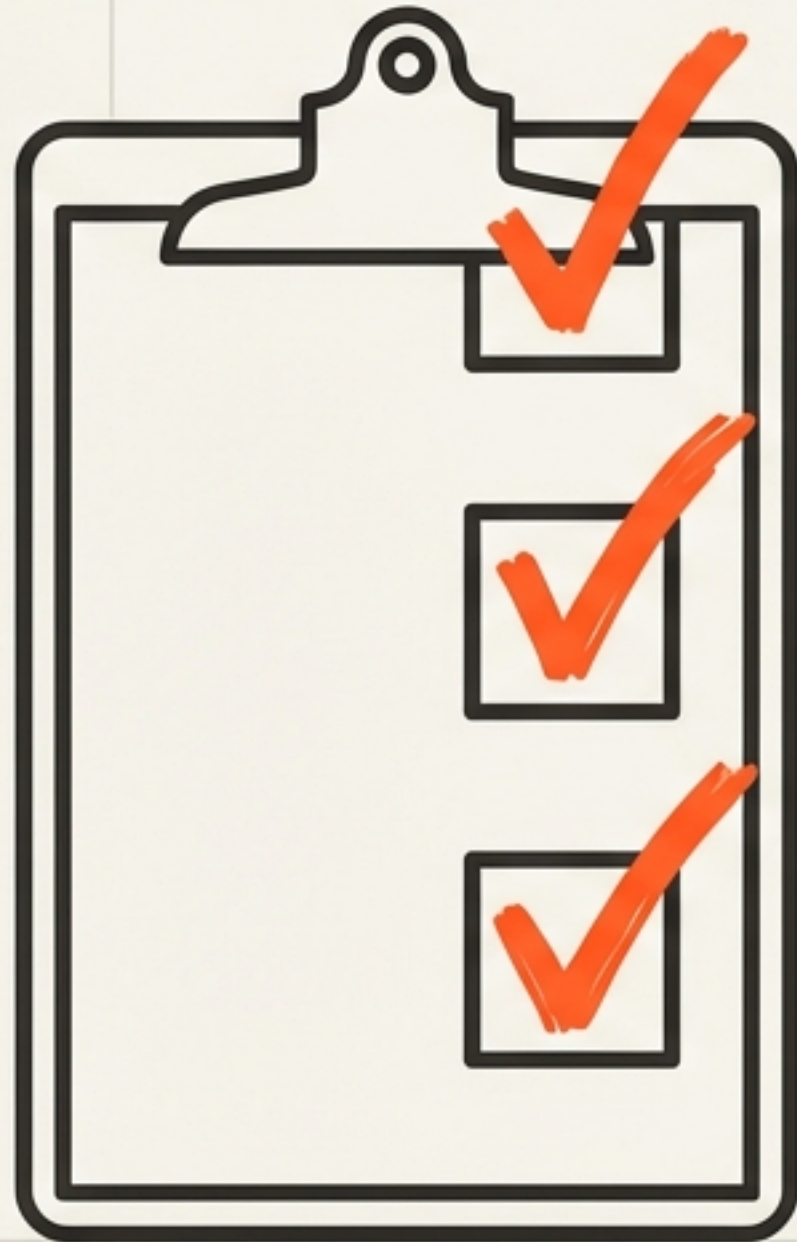
(Push people to decide)



PERSUADE

(Use data/logic, not authority)

START TODAY



Ask for Criticism.

In your next 1:1, ask “What can I stop doing?” and count to six.

Identify Your Rock Stars.

Who is the “Rock” on your team? Go thank them.

Check Your Fly.

If you see a problem, say it. It's not mean, it's clear.

YOUR HUMANITY IS AN ASSET, NOT A LIABILITY.